

names that came through with Amre and his fellow junior selectors working with Vengsarkar are familiar: Irfan Pathan, Dinesh Karthick, R.P. Singh, Robin Uthappa, V.R.V. Singh, Piyush Chawla, Suresh Raina. The barrel is not, he believes, empty. "We need to go out and spot talent, groom it, be patient with it, monitor it and not abandon young players if they struggle."

Vengsarkar believes, "Pravin is perseverant, he is patient. He can play a important role in our junior cricket. I feel the best people must be employed to look after young cricketers. The wrong person can ruin a young cricketer's career."

Amre is currently coach with Ranji champions Mumbai after doing his Level II coaching course in South Africa when he played provincial cricket for Boland, and his Level III when it was first offered in India. His training as coach has added to his judgement as selector. As junior chairman, Amre was diligent, a believer in monitoring those he was meant to keep an eye on. The scoreboard was not the benchmark for selection, the conditions in which scores are made or wickets taken are paramount. With information sourced and stored in his computer, Amre's meetings would end in 15 minutes.

His colleagues speak of his open mind and his ease with new technology and old tools: a cricketer's instinct and his eyes. He says, "With juniors, you have to reinforce in them what they're doing right rather than criticise them for doing something wrong. Most of the times they really don't understand what their own talent is."

RAVI S SAHNI

OPERATIONS

VIJAY DAHIYA

So what makes former Delhi captain and India wicket-keeper Vijay Dahiya the man to keep an eye on the many arms of the cricket business? To see that grounds are being maintained, equipment is being used, contracts are being honoured and a game's clock-work universe is in order? In Delhi, they will only point to the St. Stephen's Ground and say, look.

It was once a place for truckers to rest their vehicles, a haven for drug addicts and general vagrants, the famous college's grounds had deteriorated through disuse and abuse.

The college sought some of its old cricketing glory back and an old student, Dahiya, who is employed for Indian Airlines, was up for the job that began in 2005. It took him a year-and-a-half to have the area cleared, to get a round-the-clock guard put in place around the fringes of the ground to keep the layabouts at bay.

Today, nearly 50 train at the St. Stephen's Cricket Academy, which is run by Dahiya on a day-to-day basis. The college has two grounds, nine match strips in good shape, and a field that has gone from murky brown to lush green. Like all wicket-keepers, it seems, Dahiya, 34, comes armed with enough skill and smarts to survive in the shark pool that is Indian cricket.

NEW PITCH: Dahiya has ensured St. Stephen's ground regains its glory

RARE GEM: Ferrer at the RDT stadium, Anantapur



GROUNDS AND GRASSROOTS

MONCHO FERRER

Anantapur is a southwesterly district in Andhra Pradesh that houses one of the game's best kept secrets. A Ranji Trophy venue with a lively wicket and an outfield that Moncho Ferrer, president of the Anantapur District Cricket Association, says, "is the best in the country". This, in a town, said to be the most arid in India after Jaisalmer.

The Rural Development Trust Stadium has hosted six Ranji Trophy games and could provide the prototype for that elusive of entities: a lively Indian wicket. Ferrer, 36, researched pitch preparation, sent his team out for samples, tested them, met with experts in engineering college, before his team found their answer: the black soil from the coastal parts of northern Andhra Pradesh in the Godavari region can be used to prepare wickets that make Indian fast bowlers burst into song.

Neighbouring Karnataka heard and borrowed the formula to lay three new wickets at the Chinnaswamy Stadium, used in the national Twenty 20 and the Afro-Asia Cup. Ferrer says, "I'm at a very low level in cricket administration, but am glad we have been able to do something in this small town." BCCI bigwig I.S. Bindra's dream is to have a proper ground in every district: if he finds someone who knows how it's done, he doesn't need to go too far. Only to Anantapur.

